

“standard operating procedures,” or SOPs, particularly when Marines are in harm's way. SOPs are developed according to the three-step process mentioned above, which is designed to establish the most robust, effective, and systematic decision-making process possible.

One example is the SOP for setting up a defensive position in a combat situation.⁷ In the first phase of SOP development, experienced combat veterans and expert consultants review past data and lessons from the field to develop a set of rules that Marines will follow when establishing a defensive position. These rules are debated and agreed upon in an environment that emphasizes slow, deliberate, and critical thought. The current rules, or SOP, for a defensive position is summarized by the acronym SAFE:

- Security
- Automatic weapons on avenues of approach
- Fields of fire
- Entrenchment

During the second phase—the implementation phase—of SAFE, Marines in combat are directed to “follow the model,” or adhere to the SOP. The last thing a Marine should do is disregard SOPs in the middle of a firefight, when the environment is chaotic, Marines are tired, and human decisions are most prone to error. Marines are trained from the beginning to avoid “comfort-based” decisions and to follow standard operating procedures. Of course, once the battle is over, Marines in the field will conduct a debrief and send this information back to the experts, who can debate and assess in a calm environment whether the current SOP needs to be changed based on empirical experience gleaned from the field—the third phase. A key principle of this three-step decision-making process is that discretionary experts are required to develop and assess, but execution is made systematic, so as to minimize human error. The Marines, like other critical decision makers, want experts to develop and assess SOPs in a stable training environment. However, the Marines want to implement SOPs systematically when the environment shifts from the training environment to the live battlefield.